

Geek culture : *Androids*

The concept of Androids (robots that look like men) has been around for centuries, with many mythologies and fairy tales describing

automated clay or wooden figures of human beings given some kind of movement by divine intervention. Pinocchio is an example. Technology has caught up, but our androids are a little awkward and slow on the uptake. Moreover, men are more interested in making gynoids, female-looking robots. We wait for the world domination.

Movies

Terminator 2 (1991)

Terminator 2 showcased a deadly CGI Android made of a mutating liquid metal alloy that could shapeshift into likeness of anyone it came in contact with.



Bicentennial Man (1999)

The film, based on Asimov's book traces Andrew the Android's life over two centuries. He starts off as an Android servant, and becomes a man with equal rights.



The Second Renaissance (2003)

Two episodes in the Animatrix series, *The Second Renaissance* shows the other side of the machine vs. human war story; makes you almost sympathise with those androids.



Books

The Hitchhiker's Guide

Douglas Adam's Hitchhiker's guide trilogy of 5 and a 1/2 books introduced Marvin the "paranoid android". The radio plays and the books together made the word "android" common.



When HARLIE was one

One of those classics works of fiction where the Android in question thinks he is a human. A psychologist has to help HARLIE come to terms with his "condition".



I, Robot

Contrary to popular belief, Asimov did not write all the stories in the collection called I, Robot. Asimov however was the editor, and compiled the collection of nine short stories dealing with robotics.



Androids

Geminoid

Professor Ishiguro of Osaka decided to make a android twin of himself. He used his own body as the mould, and even gave the robot his hair. Then he programmed in AI similar to his own behavior.



Jules

Jules is the brainchild of Hanson robotics, the people who stuck Einstein's head on a decepticon, if you remember. This one has pretty realistic AI, remembers conversations, and has more motors on his face than the rest of the body.



Gakutensoku

Believe it or not, this is a servos and wires version of a gears and rubber tubes robot made way back in the 1920s in (where else?) Japan. Gakutensoku 2.0 has a lot of facial expressions, and can write on paper with a pen!



Digit Diary

Whoever said pigeons are great at navigating was an idiot. A pigeon navigated right into a small space between the toilet window and the grill, and couldn't navigate its way out. For four days, the toilet was haunted by the steadily weakening noises of a pigeon in distress. Rossi thought he would help things by wedging open the toilet door with a chair, and the entrance with another chair. The pigeon, however, stayed put. Vijay took pity and asked the watchman to free the pigeon, and the watchman caught the weak little thing in his hand-

kerchief. Seconds after he set it free, however, a very happy pussycat walked away, its mouth too full to meow.

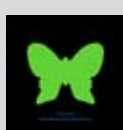
The team moved into the office for the Anniversary Issue, and needed a few provisions. Ahmed gave us his computer, his mattresses, and some pillows. Our eyes are on his 42" Plasma screen next. Rossi however, is not so kind hearted. All Robert wanted was Rossi to bring his guitar to office, but Rossi refused. The whole team pleaded like crazy, but Rossi didn't budge, and was as adamant as the pigeon. The team was reduced to listen to Crazy Frog on the Genelecs that had come in for testing.

How we unwind



Movies

Afro Samurai: Story about a black samurai on a quest to be No. 1 and at the same time avenge his father's death.



Music

Left Right Left Right Left: The new free album from coldplay. Also everyone got to run their favorites through the Genelecs.



Game

Edge: A great puzzle game if you have an iPhone.
Braid: We can't have enough of the demo. It's on the DVD.